MSEP Area 2025 Data Summaries

Mississippi Sound Estuary Program

July 31, 2026

Table of contents

Introduction **6**

I Weather and Climate-related variables **7**

1 Precipitation **8**
1.1 Overall Summary . . . 8
1.2 Supporting Information . . . 8
1.2.1 Annual Totals . . . 8
1.2.2 Monthly Totals . . . 10
1.2.3 Tropical Events . . . 12
1.2.4 Drought Index . . . 12
1.2.5 El Nino . . . 12
About . . . 12

2 Freshwater Inflows **13**
2.1 Overall Summary . . . 13
2.2 Supporting Information . . . 13
2.2.1 Rivers . . . 13
2.2.2 Mobile Bay . . . 13
2.2.3 Bonnet Carre . . . 13
About . . . 14

II People and Land Use **15**

3 Population **16**
3.1 Overall Summary . . . 16
3.2 Supporting Information . . . 16
About . . . 16

4 Land Use / Land Cover **17**
4.1 Overall Summary . . . 17
4.2 Supporting Information . . . 17
About . . . 17

III Water Conditions **18**

5 Salinity **19**
5.1 Overall Summary . . . 19
5.2 Supporting Information . . . 19
5.2.1 Deployed Sensors . . . 19
5.2.2 DMR fisheries and shrimp sampling . . . 19
5.2.3 Mississippi Coastal Assessment . . . 19
5.2.4 Other salinity data in the area . . . 19
About . . . 19

6 Dissolved Oxygen **20**
6.1 Overall Summary . . . 20
6.2 Supporting Information . . . 20
6.2.1 DEQ data . . . 20
6.2.2 Deployed Sensors . . . 20
6.2.3 DMR fisheries and shrimp sampling . . . 20
6.2.4 Mississippi Coastal Assessment . . . 20
6.2.5 Other salinity data in the area . . . 20
About . . . 20

7 Turbidity / Suspended Solids **22**
7.1 Overall Summary . . . 22
7.2 Supporting Information . . . 22
7.2.1 Turbidity - Deployed Sensors . . . 22
7.2.2 TSS - DEQ Beach Sampling . . . 22
7.2.3 TSS - Mississippi Coastal Assessment . . . 22
7.2.4 Other data in the area . . . 22
About . . . 22

8 Nutrients **23**
8.1 Overall Summary . . . 23
8.2 Supporting Information . . . 23
8.2.1 DEQ Beach Sampling . . . 23
8.2.2 DEQ Freshwater Programs . . . 23
8.2.3 Mississippi Coastal Assessment . . . 23
8.2.4 Other data in the area . . . 23
About . . . 23

9 Chlorophyll *a* **24**
9.1 Overall Summary . . . 24
9.2 Supporting Information . . . 24
9.2.1 DEQ Beach Sampling . . . 24

9.2.2 DEQ Freshwater Programs . . . 24
9.2.3 Mississippi Coastal Assessment . . . 24
9.2.4 Other data in the area . . . 24
About . . . 24

IV Pollutants/Contaminants **25**

10 Beach Advisories **26**
10.1 Overall Summary . . . 26
10.2 Supporting Information . . . 26
10.2.1 DEQ Beach Sampling . . . 26
About . . . 27

11 Shellfish Closures **28**
11.1 Overall Summary . . . 28
11.2 Supporting Information . . . 28
11.2.1 DMR . . . 28
About . . . 28

12 Impaired Waterbodies **29**
12.1 Overall Summary . . . 29
12.2 Supporting Information . . . 29
12.2.1 DEQ Info . . . 29
About . . . 29

Appendices **30**

A Data Processing **30**
A.1 Weather and Climate-related variables . . . 30
A.1.1 Precipitation . . . 30
A.1.2 Freshwater Inflows . . . 30
A.2 People and Land Use . . . 30
A.2.1 Population . . . 30
A.2.2 Land Use / Land Cover . . . 30
A.3 Water Conditions . . . 30
A.3.1 Salinity . . . 30
A.3.2 Dissolved Oxygen . . . 31
A.3.3 Turbidity / Suspended Solids . . . 31
A.3.4 Nutrients . . . 31
A.3.5 Chlorophyll *a* . . . 31
A.4 Pollutants/Contaminants . . . 31
A.4.1 Beach Advisories . . . 31

A.4.2 Shellfish Closures 31
A.4.3 Impaired Waterbodies 31
About 31

Introduction

This website is a collection of documents summarizing the condition of the Mississippi Sound and its watershed in 2025, as compared to "baseline" conditions (which we also need to define, at appropriate spatial scales for each parameter). This will be the technical supporting information for what ultimately goes into a State of the Sound report. The State of the Sound will be public-facing, whereas the intended audience for this document is largely technical.

The outputs are compiled as a 'quarto book'. Each chapter is produced by a separate `.qmd` file.

The purpose of the book format is to make the outputs readily findable and accessible. It also serves as an outline for future undertakings like a complete baseline characterization of these parameters and future State of the Sound reports.

You can download a pdf version of this entire book by clicking on the pdf icon on the right side of the toolbar at the top of this page.

Part I

Weather and Climate-related variables

1 Precipitation

From my brainstorming:

Precipitation (annual total, but also seasonal amounts - seasonality could be weird and still yield normal totals) Can have maps of actual data and summary tables of anomalies

- Maybe use gridded values to compare to 30-year climate normals; calculate anomalies, at the pixel-level; and average to whatever scale the working groups like, for a table (report each year's status: about normal, higher than normal, lower than normal; of course we have to define those categories too).

- I'm envisioning "Coastal Streams", "Upper Pascagoula", "Lower Pascagoula", "Upper Pearl", "Lower Pearl", where those are various combinations of HUCs.

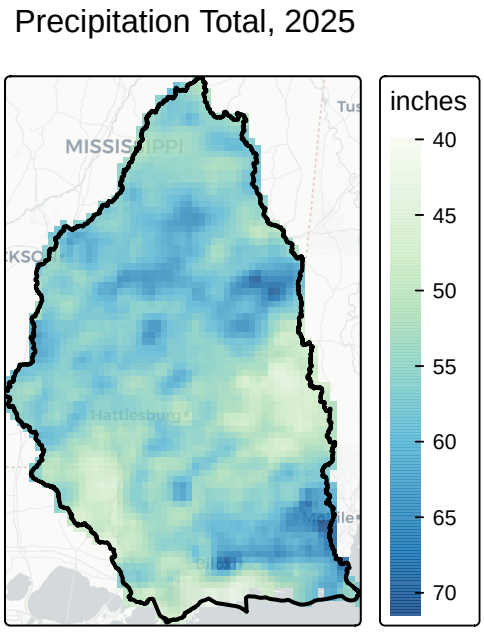
1.1 Overall Summary

Note: These summaries are NOT factual. They are examples of how we might want to talk about what we find, to help ensure we do calculations in the right way. I am completely making up details and could be very, very wrong. Please do not treat this information as factual.

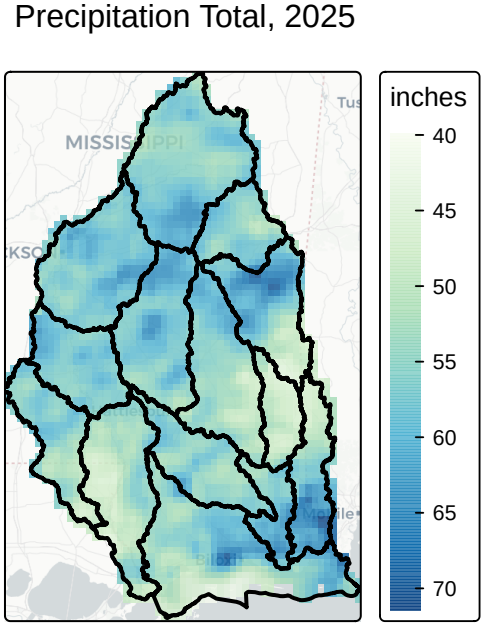
1.2 Supporting Information

1.2.1 Annual Totals

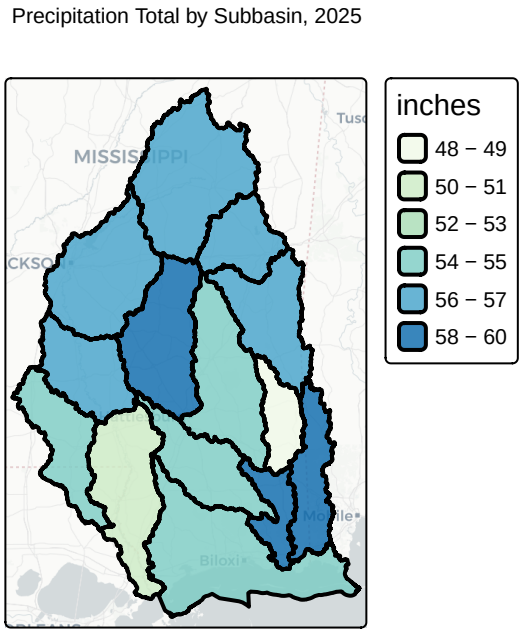
Annual totals were calculated from monthly precipitation data obtained from the PRISM Group at Oregon State University, https://prism.oregonstate.edu which were accessed 29 July 2026.



Here is the same map, but with HUC8s outlined.



Averaged to HUC8:

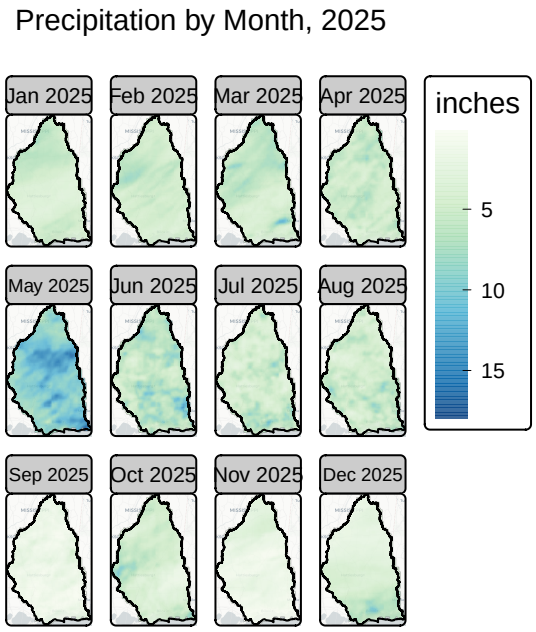


1.2.1.1 This would be a great place for a map of anomaly from …. climate normal? … by HUC8

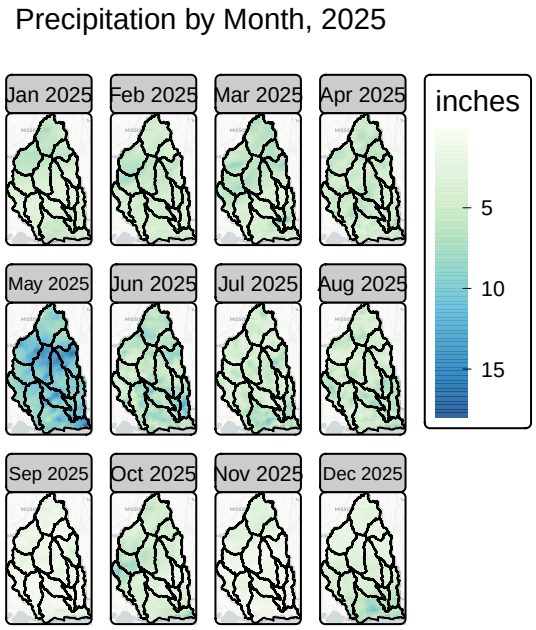
Because the climate normal on the coast is upwards of 60 inches, and it looks like the coast was in the mid-50s range in 2025, which is a little drier than normal. Climate normals in the northern part of the watershed are in the mid-to-upper 50s so they look about typical for 2025. I'm eyeballing here and the color scale is slightly different, but see the MSEP Characterization chapter on precipitation for the details I have compiled in the past (climate normals from NCEI).

1.2.2 Monthly Totals

Monthly data are from the PRISM Group at Oregon State University, https://prism.oregonstate.edu and were accessed 29 July 2026.

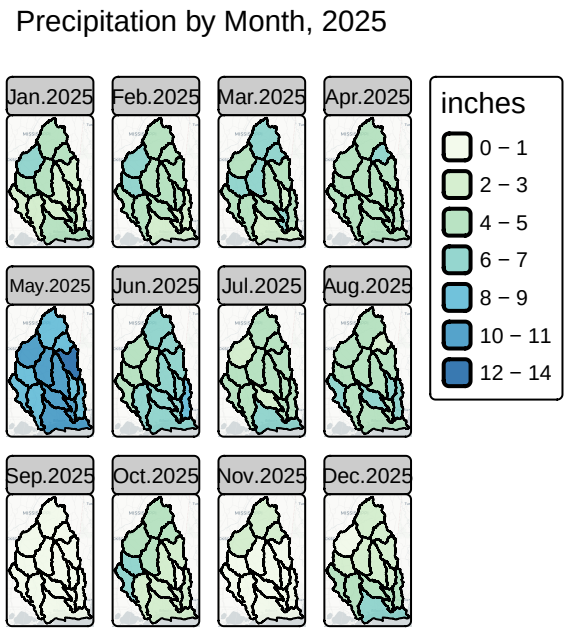


Here is the same map, but with HUC8s outlined.



This may be too many subdivisions to try and summarize. Here's what things look like averaged to the HUC8 level though, which will keep it simpler and make it easier to make

comparisons to historical data.



May seems to have been the wettest month in 2025, and that's not really typical - actually in the climate normals (see them here), the color scale only goes up to 8.5 inches per month, and May 2025 exceeded that.

1.2.3 Tropical Events

1.2.4 Drought Index

1.2.5 El Nino

About

The `.qmd` file that generated this section was: **precipitation.qmd**.

For information on data sources and processing, see *appendix cross-reference here*.

2 Freshwater Inflows

2.1 Overall Summary

Note: These summaries are NOT factual. They are examples of how we might want to talk about what we find, to help ensure we do calculations in the right way. I am completely making up details and could be very, very wrong. Please do not treat this information as factual.

e.g. "River inputs were about average this year", or "Pearl River inputs were higher than normal, while Pascagoula River inputs were lower than normal", or "Flows from both main rivers were higher than normal this year, and the Bonnet Carre spillway was open for a substantial amount of time, causing XYZ impacts".

2.2 Supporting Information

2.2.1 Rivers

Pearl and Pascagoula River USGS gauges

2.2.2 Mobile Bay

?? certainly affects the Eastern Sound, even if exact amount is in question (estimates vary; I have some references if we want to talk about this) so probably worth noting.

2.2.3 Bonnet Carre

- number of openings
- number of days open
- Volume released

About

The `.qmd` file that generated this section was: **freshwater_inflows.qmd**.

For information on data sources and processing, see *appendix cross-reference here*.

Part II

People and Land Use

3 Population

3.1 Overall Summary

Note: These summaries are NOT factual. They are examples of how we might want to talk about what we find, to help ensure we do calculations in the right way. I am completely making up details and could be very, very wrong. Please do not treat this information as factual.

e.g. "Population has been steady in the watershed for the last 10 years"

3.2 Supporting Information

See population calculations in the msep_geospatialCharacterization repository, and repeat them for current year vs. 5, 10, 20 years ago.

About

The `.qmd` file that generated this section was: **population.qmd**.

For information on data sources and processing, see *appendix cross-reference here*.

4 Land Use / Land Cover

4.1 Overall Summary

Note: These summaries are NOT factual. They are examples of how we might want to talk about what we find, to help ensure we do calculations in the right way. I am completely making up details and could be very, very wrong. Please do not treat this information as factual.

e.g. "The coastal counties of the watershed have become more developed in the last 10 years, while developed landcover in the more inland counties has remained relatively stable"

4.2 Supporting Information

About

The `.qmd` file that generated this section was: **landuse_landcover.qmd**.

For information on data sources and processing, see *appendix cross-reference here*.

Part III

Water Conditions

5 Salinity

5.1 Overall Summary

Note: These summaries are NOT factual. They are examples of how we might want to talk about what we find, to help ensure we do calculations in the right way. I am completely making up details and could be very, very wrong. Please do not treat this information as factual.

e.g. "Salinity was lower than normal, and this was more pronounced in the Eastern Sound than the rest of the area." Tie back to Chapter 1 and Chapter 2 chapters.

5.2 Supporting Information

5.2.1 Deployed Sensors

USGS/DMR hydrological stations, DMR sensor network, USM-GCRL stations (in the future), Grand Bay NERR SWMP stations

5.2.2 DMR fisheries and shrimp sampling

5.2.3 Mississippi Coastal Assessment

5.2.4 Other salinity data in the area

About

The `.qmd` file that generated this section was: **salinity.qmd**.

For information on data sources and processing, see *appendix cross-reference here*.

6 Dissolved Oxygen

6.1 Overall Summary

Note: These summaries are NOT factual. They are examples of how we might want to talk about what we find, to help ensure we do calculations in the right way. I am completely making up details and could be very, very wrong. Please do not treat this information as factual.

e.g. "Hypoxia was more (or less) prevalent than usual in the eastern Sound and its bays, and about normal elsewhere along the coast. In freshwater streams and rivers, hypoxia was about normal."

6.2 Supporting Information

6.2.1 DEQ data

Inland sampling network programs

6.2.2 Deployed Sensors

USGS/DMR hydrological stations, DMR sensor network, USM-GCRL stations (in the future), Grand Bay NERR SWMP stations

6.2.3 DMR fisheries and shrimp sampling

6.2.4 Mississippi Coastal Assessment

6.2.5 Other salinity data in the area

About

The `.qmd` file that generated this section was: **dissolved_oxygen.qmd**.

For information on data sources and processing, see *appendix cross-reference here.*

7 Turbidity / Suspended Solids

7.1 Overall Summary

Note: These summaries are NOT factual. They are examples of how we might want to talk about what we find, to help ensure we do calculations in the right way. I am completely making up details and could be very, very wrong. Please do not treat this information as factual.

e.g. "Turbidity was lower than normal (clearer water!) in the rivers and streams, while Total Suspended Solids were higher than normal across the Sound."

7.2 Supporting Information

7.2.1 Turbidity - Deployed Sensors

DMR sensor network, USM-GCRL stations (in the future), Grand Bay NERR SWMP stations

7.2.2 TSS - DEQ Beach Sampling

7.2.3 TSS - Mississippi Coastal Assessment

7.2.4 Other data in the area

Grand Bay SWMP has been doing TSS since ~2021

About

The `.qmd` file that generated this section was: **turb_tss.qmd**.

For information on data sources and processing, see *appendix cross-reference here.*

8 Nutrients

May want to split this into N and P; there are different species of each and that might be a lot for one chapter.

8.1 Overall Summary

Note: These summaries are NOT factual. They are examples of how we might want to talk about what we find, to help ensure we do calculations in the right way. I am completely making up details and could be very, very wrong. Please do not treat this information as factual.

e.g. "Nitrogen and phosphorus concentrations were higher than normal, and this was more pronounced in the Eastern Sound than the rest of the area. This coincides with extreme Bonnet Carre inputs."

8.2 Supporting Information

8.2.1 DEQ Beach Sampling

8.2.2 DEQ Freshwater Programs

8.2.3 Mississippi Coastal Assessment

8.2.4 Other data in the area

Grand Bay SWMP

About

The `.qmd` file that generated this section was: **nutrients.qmd**.

For information on data sources and processing, see *appendix cross-reference here.*

9 Chlorophyll *a*

Make sure to note whether programs are using "chl corrected for phaeophytin" or "not corrected for phaeophytin".

9.1 Overall Summary

Note: These summaries are NOT factual. They are examples of how we might want to talk about what we find, to help ensure we do calculations in the right way. I am completely making up details and could be very, very wrong. Please do not treat this information as factual.

e.g. "Chlorophyll was about normal across coastal waterbodies this year."

9.2 Supporting Information

9.2.1 DEQ Beach Sampling

9.2.2 DEQ Freshwater Programs

9.2.3 Mississippi Coastal Assessment

uses uncorrected chl

9.2.4 Other data in the area

Grand Bay SWMP; uses corrected chl

About

The `.qmd` file that generated this section was: **chla.qmd**.

For information on data sources and processing, see *appendix cross-reference here.*

Part IV

Pollutants/Contaminants

10 Beach Advisories

This section will be based on data from beaches.mdeq.ms.gov.

10.1 Overall Summary

Note: These summaries are NOT factual. They are examples of how we might want to talk about what we find, to help ensure we do calculations in the right way. I am completely making up details and could be very, very wrong. Please do not treat this information as factual.

e.g. "Overall, the number of beach advisory days was lower than normal, and at *example hot spot stations* in particular, the number has been decreasing."

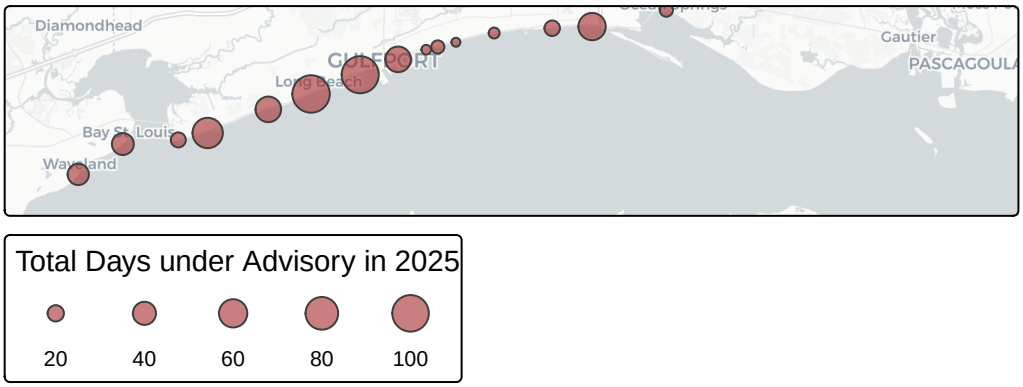
10.2 Supporting Information

10.2.1 DEQ Beach Sampling

Make a map where each station is represented by a point, and the point size is based on the number of days that station was under advisory in the year.

no. of beach closure days by station (see PPBEP's online map)

- Can download advisory/closure info from DEQ: https://beaches.mdeq.ms.gov/Historical/HCA
- Per station, calculate # advisories/closures, # days under advisory/closure (total), mean or median # days per advisory/closure
- Aggregate across coast: how many days under advisory/closure across all stations (sum of station totals); break down whether it's just a few troublesome sites (seems to be based on presentations I've seen from DEQ) and what % of advisory/closure days came from those few sites



About

The `.qmd` file that generated this section was: **beach_advisories.qmd**.

For information on data sources and processing, see *appendix cross-reference here*.

11 Shellfish Closures

This section will be based on data from MDMR.

11.1 Overall Summary

Note: These summaries are NOT factual. They are examples of how we might want to talk about what we find, to help ensure we do calculations in the right way. I am completely making up details and could be very, very wrong. Please do not treat this information as factual.

e.g. "Shellfish beds were closed less than normal this year."

11.2 Supporting Information

11.2.1 DMR

About

The `.qmd` file that generated this section was: **shellfish_closures.qmd**.

For information on data sources and processing, see *appendix cross-reference here.*

12 Impaired Waterbodies

This section will be based on DEQ's 303d list.

12.1 Overall Summary

Note: These summaries are NOT factual. They are examples of how we might want to talk about what we find, to help ensure we do calculations in the right way. I am completely making up details and could be very, very wrong. Please do not treat this information as factual.

Here just the number of miles (rivers/streams) or acres (lakes, estuaries) that are listed as impaired. Was this more or less than the last State of the Sound report?

12.2 Supporting Information

12.2.1 DEQ Info

About

The `.qmd` file that generated this section was: **impaired_waterbodies.qmd**.

For information on data sources and processing, see *appendix cross-reference here.*

A Data Processing

In general, links to original data sources are provided in each section below. Because data files are routinely updated, the files as downloaded and used in this document are also available online. These files are provided for reproducibility and transparency; for your own analyses, we encourage you to seek out data from the original linked sources.

A.1 Weather and Climate-related variables

A.1.1 Precipitation

Go back to Chapter 1

A.1.2 Freshwater Inflows

Go back to Chapter 2

A.2 People and Land Use

A.2.1 Population

Go back to Chapter 3

A.2.2 Land Use / Land Cover

Go back to Chapter 4

A.3 Water Conditions

A.3.1 Salinity

Go back to Chapter 5

A.3.2 Dissolved Oxygen

Go back to Chapter 6

A.3.3 Turbidity / Suspended Solids

Go back to Chapter 7

A.3.4 Nutrients

Go back to Chapter 8

A.3.5 Chlorophyll *a*

Go back to Chapter 9

A.4 Pollutants/Contaminants

A.4.1 Beach Advisories

Go back to Chapter 10

A.4.2 Shellfish Closures

Go back to Chapter 11

A.4.3 Impaired Waterbodies

Go back to Chapter 12

About

The `.qmd` file that generated this section was: **data_processing.qmd**.